well as had a generic focus on making government systems more efficient.

So, is Modi a socialist? In an interview in late 2019, the BJP's Rajya Sabha member Rajeev Chandrasekhar told me that he put this very question to the prime minister. 'I've asked him, sir, are you, are we Socialist? He said—and I don't mind being quoted—he has told me very clearly: "I believe in free markets and opportunities and growth for those private sector companies that follow the law and do so through innovation, through fair competition, not through political connections. I want a robust private sector, but I want a private sector that is ethical, that is focused on the business. And why do I want it? Because only that will increase the fiscal headroom of the government through taxes and indirect taxes. So, as a government, as a political party, I believe in a strong safety net for these 300–400 million Indians that still need to be taken out of poverty. I need the fiscal headroom for that, and for that fiscal headroom, I need a strong private sector. So, on the left side of my mind, I am strongly private sector oriented. On the right side of my mind, I am a strong statist, in the sense that the state and the welfare state must intervene strongly, solidly in a clear corruption free-manner to help these 30 crore people."'[124]

Is it right, then, to compare Modi with Thatcher or Reagan? Chandrasekhar had asked the prime minister about this too: how, early on, people had made a comparison with Thatcher when he came to power. He said that Modi's response convinced him that this was a wrong comparison to make. In fact, did the policies of the government on social welfare make it, in practice, more left than the Left? 'Absolutely,' Chandrasekhar said.

'So, I asked him [Modi] this question if he wanted to be a Thatcher and he said: "Absolutely I don't want to be, I'm not getting some Nobel prize in economics. I don't want to be known as rightist, centrist or leftist. I want strong commerce, trade, industry in this country. I want that to be driven by the private sector. I want that to be done by private capital. I want the fiscal headroom that this creates and the state revenues to be spent wisely in a manner so that, in the next five to eight years, a whole new middle class is created. So that the middle class that today we say is 100 million, we